

Henry ‘Orator’ Hunt

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Henry Hunt was born in Upavon, Wiltshire in 1773. He was a tall well-built man and from a comfortable background. He could easily have settled into the life of a gentleman farmer in Wiltshire. However, a minor local quarrel led to him spending six weeks in the Kings Bench prison, and he was then ostracised by Wiltshire society.

On his release, he spent some time in Brighton and, though married, fell deeply in love with Mrs. Vince, with whom he eloped in 1802. He had by then got interested in politics. His commanding presence and good speaking voice made him a popular speaker, earning him the sobriquet of Henry ‘Orator’ Hunt. He was a leading radical and was to have been the lead speaker at the mass meeting in Manchester which became known as the Peterloo Massacre, but the Yeomanry charged before he could speak.

This page, however, is concerned solely with his later interest in the politics of the City of London. A series of successful mass meetings in Spa Fields in 1816–17 found Hunt at odds with Robert Waithman, an established City Tory. Hunt judged it a good time to stand up for the interests of the rate-payers against the corrupt establishment. At Common Hall he carried a motion for the City’s accounts to be published and distributed to all ratepayers. Waithman refused, claiming there were no funds. Hunt replied in 1827: “No funds! There was enough cash for gormandizing, for guzzling, for treating emperors and kings, for stuffing themselves, and for carrying some home in their pockets.”

In a misguided attempt to stifle Hunt, he was nominated for the post of auditor and was elected by an overwhelming show of hands. Hunt used the post to campaign for reform, retrenchment, and accountability. He objected to the system whereby the Lord Mayor was chosen by rotation and campaigned for changes to the office of secondary under-sheriff, which he believed empowered the holder “to oppress, plunder, and rob” anyone arrested within the City. The recorder and other



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legal officers were also censured for their inflated salaries, innumerable perquisites and expensive feasts at the Old Bailey.

When his term of office as auditor came to an end in 1829, he refused a retirement dinner and asked that the money should be distributed to poor freemen. The Chamberlain refused, saying it could only be used for ‘eating or drinking’, so Hunt proposed feeding 400 widows of freemen instead. This too was refused.

In 1824, Hunt stood twice for election as a common councilman in Farringdon Without but was defeated both times and subjected to considerable personal vilification.

A better chance came when the City authorities petitioned Parliament for financial assistance for the approaches to the new London Bridge. Hunt advised the Lords not to continue the tax on coals or advance public money, so the Lords required Common Council to produce its annual accounts.

At the following Common Hall, a resolution compelled City officials to keep receipts and produce timely annual accounts for audit.

Distress about social conditions intensified in 1830, and the City petitioned for a parliamentary inquiry. Waithman tried to restrict the scope, but Hunt argued that the chief cause was the long, expensive wars against the liberties of America and France, worsened by the unrepresentative House of Commons.

Reform gathered pace under Earl Grey’s Whig government. Hunt became MP for Preston in 1830, but his equivocal reaction to the Reform Bill probably contributed to his defeat in 1833.

In 1832, Hunt presented to the House of Commons the first individual petition for a vote. It was from Mary Smith of Stanmore in Yorkshire, who argued that because she paid taxes and obeyed the law, she should be allowed to vote. The petition was laughed out.

Hunt’s health deteriorated in 1834, and he died at Alresford in 1835.